

something you like, and it better be something that's going to make you enough money for you to be happy. Better yet, it should be enough money that you'll have extra to spend on your interests. This isn't about ignoring your passions. Photography has been my passion since I was a teenager. But when I announced to my parents that my plan was to be a photographer, my stepfather sat me down for a little talk.

He said, "It's good that you know what you want to *be*, but what do you want to *do* for a living?"

I didn't understand. Do? Be? I didn't realize there was a difference.

"Do you have any idea what you have to *do* in order to be a photographer?" he asked. I scratched my head.

"Let's put it this way," he continued. "How much money do you think you'll need to make to be happy?"

I pulled a figure out of my head: \$20,000, which was a decent income back then. George laughed. He explained that most photographers, starting out, don't make that kind of money. Then he explained the harsh realities of following my passion as a career instead of as an outlet.

"You might not be good enough, Kevin, and the wrong time to find that out is on the other side of a big debt."

If I sound like I'm discouraging genuine talent, I'm not. In fact, I don't think it's really possible to do that. I am discouraging people from committing to expensive degrees from colleges and universities that sell a pipe dream. "*Study this and you'll be guaranteed a job!*" Remember this, kids: Colleges and universities are businesses. Even though many are structured like charities and have loftier mandates than corporations, colleges have bottom lines and ever-increasing operating costs. They have to fill desks, too.

So before you commit to an expensive course of action, take a lesson from my stepfather. He taught me that if I knew how to *do* something, I could *be* anything. Want to be a photographer? Great, go to business school and get your MBA as a fallback. Want to be a writer? Get your journalism degree, and make sure to take the technical courses as well, such as editing and camera operating, just to be safe. Want to act? Get a teaching degree and you'll have a rapt